In fact, during one of the early tests, there was an accident at Mahendragiri—something no media could sniff out. There was a leak of N2O4 in the test stand pit. The scene was quite scary, with thick brown vapour spreading from the test stand. The team contained it, but not before some anxious hours. It was the only accident at Mahendragiri, and it gave ISRO a hands-on experience in firefighting with loads of water.

Chandran led a team to find a solution to the water problem. He surveyed the forest to understand the contours of the hills and designed a series of channels and check dams to guide and gather water in pits to replenish ground water. They built more than thirty such small check dams. Chandran's water harvesting measures showed result within a couple of years. The ground water table rose so much that a bore well need not go beyond 50 m in the hills.

As villagers come in during the *Panguni Uthiram* puja once a year, they comment on how their once depleted forest surrounding the temples have rejuvenated under ISRO's care. Rocket scientists, it seemed, were not as bad as they thought.

The north-east part of the campus, I explored and found, was the most beautiful, with lot of greenery and a few streams. I proposed we have our guest houses here. After all, it is not a sin for scientists, guests and others from the government to be in good surroundings when they visit Mahendragiri. But this was not to be, as the guests would have to pass through some 'danger zones' to reach the proposed guest house. So the lodgings came up on the south-east side, closer to the highways, where they are now.

Another of my plan that did not materialise was setting up a few wind mills on the Mahendragiri campus. This would have given us some green power self-sufficiency. Looking at the maps of the tail end of the Western Ghats, we found that there were quite a few wind corridors and passes where wind gathers speed because of the converging hills.

Here, we were sitting on some 6,000 acres with fantastic wind for at least three months. When I made the suggestion, some others said we are here to test rocket engines, not harness wind. Of course we were here to test